

Escalation Support for Families



Try This:

Brainstorm your personal reset anchors before the hard moments hit. Is it taking a sip of cold water, looking in the trees for birds, listening to your favourite song? Use your anchor first, so you have regulation to offer your child.

Why this happens: You can't loan calm if your own nervous system is activated. When a child's meltdown triggers your own stress, "just taking a breath" usually isn't enough. You need to know what actually grounds you before you can steady them.

What is one quick anchor that genuinely helps you feel steady when stress spikes at home?

Rung 1 of 10

Find Your Anchor First

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Why this happens: Your child works hard to follow rules all day at kinder. When they see you, their body relaxes because you are their safe place, causing all that built-up pressure to release at once.

Try This:

Expect a bit of a hiccup after kindergarten. Greet them with a quiet hug, low physical height, or gentle touch before asking any questions about their day.

How did your child express their afternoon energy at pick-up today?

Rung 2 of 10
The Pick-Up Pause

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Why this happens: After the noise and activity of group care, sitting in a moving car can feel overwhelming if there is too much radio chatter or rapid questioning.

A tired nervous system needs a low-stimulation environment to process the shift from kinder to home.

Rung 3 of 10

The Kinder Car Ride

Try This:

Match the car environment to their body state. If your child is flat, tearful, or silent, try playing low nature sounds, soft instrumental music, or enjoying genuine silence instead of asking lots of questions right away.

What stimulating or quiet moment helped settle your commute home today?

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Why this happens: Stopping at the shops right after pick-up drops a tired child straight into sensory overload. If you walk in rushed and without a plan, their exhausted brain defaults to fighting for quick dopamine (sugar or screens), leading to floor meltdowns when told "no".

Rung 4 of 10
Planning the Pick-Up
Errand

Try This:

Plan the rush before you unbuckle. Keep a clipboard and pencil in the car. Before stepping inside, hand your child their "special helper job", like hunting for 3 red apples or counting yellow price tags.

How did planning a shopping job before walking through the doors shift your errand today?

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Why this happens: Crossing the doorstep is a big transition. Giving tired bodies a simple physical job grounds nervous energy and prevents a doorway meltdown.

Try This:

Set up a quick entry ritual: lunchbox directly into the kitchen sink, shoes and socks off so their feet can touch the ground, check if the cat needs water, check the letterbox for mail, etc.

What activity or strategy helped your child settle coming inside today?

Rung 5 of 10

Unpack & Reset Ritual

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Why this happens: Physical heat and sensory stress build up during the day.

A cool touch instantly signals the nervous system's vagus nerve to slow down and reset.

Try This:

Offer a cool, damp face washer for their face and hands, or let them splash cool water at the bathroom sink as a physical circuit breaker.

What shift did you notice after offering a cool washer reset?

Rung 6 of 10
Temperature Shift

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Try This:

Take afternoon tea outside onto a soft picnic rug or lawn. Let bare feet touch the grass while eating to discharge built-up stress.

Why this happens: Eating while sitting on soft grass or a rug gives tired muscles deep grounding feedback, helping a sensory-overloaded body settle after a big day.

Where did your child eat afternoon tea, and how did their posture change?

Rung 7 of 10

Grounded Afternoon Snack

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Try This:

Set up a simple tactile activity before any screen time, like washing toy cars or dolls in a basin of soapy water, or watering garden pots.

Why this happens: Screens offer rapid visual stimulation that can make an overwhelmed brain more irritable. Hands-on sensory play calms the nervous system through touch and movement first.

What tactile play activity did your child engage with before turning on a screen?

Rung 8 of 10
Sensory Play
Before Screens

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Why this happens: The moment you arrive home, the choice is in your hands. Handing over a phone or sugary treat offers a fast dopamine flood that feels easy in the moment, but it leaves an exhausted brain more dysregulated later.

Try This:

Set screens and quick fixes aside. Offer real sensory connection first. Eg. step into the garden, inspect plants together, or sit low on the grass to ground your child's body before bringing in extra stimulation.

Which option did you choose at the door today. A quick dopamine flood, or a moment of calm?

Rung 9 of 10
Spot Dopamine Traps

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Why this happens: Looking up and out at nature widens a child's visual field, naturally lowering internal fight-or-flight tension by shifting focus away from big feelings.

Try This:

Step outside for a two-minute breather. Together, look for three fluffy clouds, count birds overhead, or find three matching green leaves.

What natural detail did you and your child notice together outside?

Rung 10 of 10
Sky & Nature Spotting